

## Hydrogen cars for everybody

A car that runs on Hydrogen was revealed recently in London and will be available in UK sometime in 2010. The manufacturers plan to make the design of this car 'open source'

## SMS craze

A 15-year old girl won the LG National Texting Championship and won a cash prize of \$50,000. She defeated 2,50,000 fellow competitors and went through various rounds including blindfolds and quizzes to win the title.

## Photo printer test

battery pack. The size has been intelligently designed to accommodate for travel purposes and the addition of a battery pack makes a huge difference in portability.

There is a magnetic clip mechanism used to open the lid of this printer, and once you open the rear lid, the small front tray also opens. This front tray is not too long and won't really hold paper, but being a portable printer, this can be overlooked. Paper is loaded from the rear tray and this can be extended to keep the paper in place.

The Pixma iP100 also has a two-button design, similar to all the other Canon photo printers we tested, and they perform the tasks of powering on/off and clearing paper jams. These buttons have small LED indicators next to them; this helps somewhat if you need to print in the dark, but complete backlit buttons would have been even better. There is a small clip near the base, where you can switch between envelope and normal paper. Unless this clip has been set in the right place, your print will not start and you will be greeted with an error.

The print quality of this Pixma iP100 was really good; similar to that of the iX5000 in some cases, but overall, managed to outperform it. The iP100 was also similar to the other Canon products in that it produced an overall warm colour in the images, though not as much as the other Canon photo printers. The first image showed detail in some parts and was able to reproduce shades of blue very well, though the darker shades of black towards the end in the greyscale test were merged. The second image revealed this printer missing out on a few dark shadows and did not blend a part of



HP Photosmart D5468

the photo correctly. The last test image did not show any major differences between the iP100 and the iX5000, but the purple pebbles were more differentiated and looked much better in the case of the iP100.

This printer is priced at Rs. 20,995, and we do feel this is a bit on the high side. But if you really need something portable, especially with the addition of a battery pack, this does make for a sensible buy, but it will not give you the best prints.

### HP Photosmart D5468

The HP Photosmart D5468, HP's one and only entry in this test, is part of its D5400 series. The printer has a nice rounded edge design with grey and white colours. There is a front facing silver bezel, atop which a 1.5-inch display is present. Next to this are the printer controls, Print photo button, red-eye removal button, cancel and power buttons.

Along with this printer being the only one in this test to have a display, other than the compact photo printers, the Photosmart D5468 also has memory card support and a USB port that can be used as a PictBridge connect; it also supports USB flash drives, another feature missing from the other photo printers.

This printer comes with two paper trays arranged one

above the other, the top tray being used only for 4 x 6 photo prints, while the lower paper tray can be used for other paper sizes, including A4. The top paper tray can be removed to make the bottom tray more accessible. This printer can also print images straight onto a CD or DVD. To do this, there is an extension located at the base of the bottom tray where the CD or DVD has to be placed.

This HP Photosmart D5468 gave us the most balanced colours of all the non-compact photo printers that we tested. The first image shows that the colours were nicely reproduced, but there was a slight concern with the greens, as two shades looked as though they were merging. This photo printer was the only one to differentiate all the colours of the black and white chart that is present on the test image. The overall reflections and ripples in the water were also much better than with the other printers.

In the second test image, though the image looked good, there was slight over-contrast of orange towards the bottom of the image. The third image showed the best results among all the printers, where the black was actually reproduced properly as black. With our Combi test document, we found that some parts that contained yellow were printed

more on the orange side. Also the yellow on black text was unreadable at smaller font sizes, something that the other printers were able to get correctly. The red cherries in the image looked good and well differentiated.

In eco-mode, there was a huge difference and you could clearly see jagged edges on the text and lots of pixels all over the image.

The HP Photosmart D5468, with a few exceptions, did reproduce some really great images and with a price tag of only Rs. 6,498, it really makes an excellent purchase.

### The final decision

If you are looking for the most basic photo printer, you don't really want to spend much money and can do with average quality, then you should get the Canon Pixma iP1980. If you want something better and are willing to pay more for it, and at the same time want added features such as PictBridge and USB flash drive support, along with something that you will use occasionally to print images on CDs, then you should definitely go for the HP Photosmart D5468.

If you are frequently printing A3 sheets, then starting off with the Canon Pixma iX5000 makes good sense, as it is an entry level A3 photo printer. If you need portability and something that prints A4 size sheets, then the Canon Pixma iP100 is a good choice. Though it might seem a tad pricey, it gives above average print quality, has a compact design and the extra battery pack is a much needed feature. If you are someone who likes to take snapshots and keep collecting them, the Canon Selphy CP 760 is the one for you as the details are superb and it also comes at a reasonable cost. 

| Contact Sheet |                                       |                         |                  |                 |
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